What Makes a Good Day, Dad?

How to ask about his routines without making it an interview.

You'd like to ask Dad how he likes his days. You don't want it to feel like you're filling in a form about him, and he may reasonably wonder why you're asking when nothing is wrong.

This guide is for a few easy conversations with one job: he tells the stories and you take the notes. It isn't for deciding anything, and any of them can stop whenever he's had enough.

Who should be there

Dad and you, to begin with. It's a conversation between the two of you before it's anything else.

AARP's planning guide for families suggests that once a conversation has started, you may wish to bring in a few other trusted family members or friends. Whether that happens, and who they are, is Dad's to say. [2]

Pick a time when nobody is rushing: over a meal, on a drive, while he's busy with something he likes doing. Bring a notebook or your phone, and tell him you'd like to jot a few things down.

How to open

Say why you're asking, in a sentence, and then ask about something he enjoys talking about.

The Conversation Project's workbook has advice for anyone helping another person through its questions: take it in small pieces, it's always okay to skip a question, and if the person gets tired, take a break and come back to it later. [1]

- “Dad, it struck me the other day that I couldn't tell anyone how you like your eggs. I'd like to know these things. Mind if I ask you a few?”
- “Nothing's wrong, and nobody's planning anything. I'd just rather ask you than guess.”
- If he says “another time,” that's his answer. Thank him and leave it there.
- Say what the conversation is for: knowing how he likes his days, in his own words. Say what it isn't for: deciding anything, or changing anything about how he lives.

Questions to ask

Ask Dad

Pick two or three for one sitting and follow the stories. If he brings up his faith or the traditions he keeps, write that down as he says it. It's his to raise.

1. What does a good day look like for you, start to finish?

2. How do you like your mornings to go? And your evenings?

3. What do you look forward to eating, and what would you be happy never to see on a plate again?

4. Who do you like to see or hear from in a week, and what do you like to be doing?

5. If someone new were helping you out for a week, what would you want them to understand about you?

Ask before you finish

These can wait for the second or third conversation, once there's a page to show him.

1. Have I got this right? What would you change?

2. Is there any of this you'd rather stayed between us, and who would you be happy to have see it?

3. When shall I ask you again?

How to write down what was said

Write his phrases, not your summary, and use quotation marks only where you caught the wording. Keep what Dad said apart from what a relative remembers. Where the two differ, write both and don't settle it.

WHAT WAS SAID	WHO SAID IT	WHEN	DIFFERENT FROM WHAT SOMEONE ELSE SAID?
“Tea first, paper second, and nobody talks to me until both are done.”	Dad	Sunday, over lunch	
Dad can't have shellfish.	My sister	Tuesday, by phone	Dad says he just never liked it

What not to decide yet

Dad is well, and nothing needs settling. Leave all of these open, however the conversation goes.

- What he'd want in a situation he hasn't talked about.

- Whether something he avoids is a taste, an allergy or a doctor's instruction. That is a question for his doctor or pharmacist.
- Which relative remembered it right.
- Anything about where he lives, or about help of any kind.

What you can agree on today

- That you'll write up what he said and read it back to him.
- Who he's happy for you to show it to, if anyone.
- How you'll come back to it: a date, an occasion, or simply “when one of us thinks of it.”

What this guide doesn't do

It doesn't settle a difference between what Dad says and what the family remembers, and it doesn't tell you what a professional would say. It gets his words onto a dated page, with the open questions left on it.

Ready for the next step?

Dad told the stories and you took the notes. The care interview gives those notes somewhere to go: it walks through his situation area by area, keeps his account beside the family's, and turns your answers into a Family Care Profile you can bring to any care conversation.

Create Your Free Family Care Profile ›

WHERE THIS COMES FROM

The good-day question and the advice to take it in small pieces come from The Conversation Project's workbook; the other questions are the Family Care Roadmap's own.

1. The Conversation Project (Institute for Healthcare Improvement) and Ariadne Labs, What Matters to Me: A Workbook for Better Health Care
2. AARP, Prepare to Care: A Planning Guide for Families